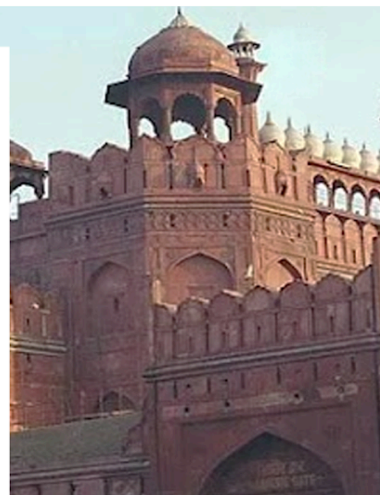
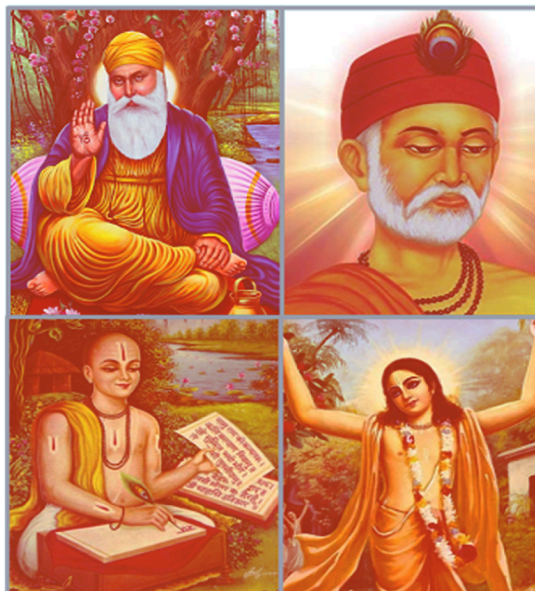
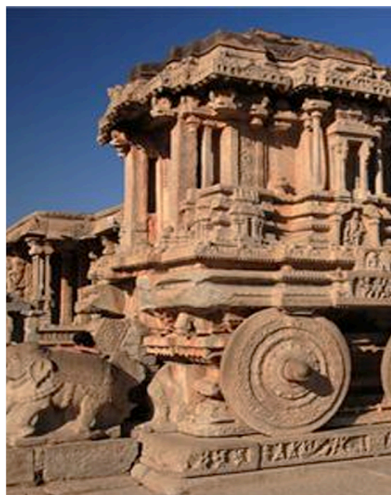


General Knowledge

Medieval History

STUDY NOTES

Aurangzeb



Aurangzeb (1658 to 1707 A.D.)



Birth and Life

- Aurangzeb, born **Muhi-ud-Din Muhammad** on November 3, 1618, was the third son of Shah Jahan and Mumtaz Mahal.
- He was the sixth Mughal emperor and is often considered the last effective ruler of the Mughal dynasty.
- His reign marked the empire's territorial peak but also laid the groundwork for its eventual decline.

Rise to Power

- Aurangzeb became viceroy of the Deccan in 1636, later serving as governor of Gujarat, Balkh, Multan, and Sindh.
- His rivalry with his elder brother, Dara Shikoh, culminated in a brutal war of succession when their father fell ill in 1657.
- Aurangzeb imprisoned Shah Jahan in Agra Fort and had Dara Shikoh executed. He took the throne in 1659 and adopted the title "**Aurangzeb Alamgir.**"

Aurangzeb's Policies

Religious Policy:

- Aurangzeb, an orthodox Sunni Muslim, lived a simple, austere life and was known as "**Zinda Pir**" (Living Saint).

- He enforced **Sharia law strictly** and took measures to align his government with Islamic principles.
- He discontinued certain royal customs, such as weighing the emperor against gold and silver, and banned public ceremonies like the Nauroz festival (associated with Zoroastrianism).
- Music and singing were banned in court, but instrumental music and the royal band (**Naubat**) continued.
- Ladies in the royal harem still patronized singing.
- Aurangzeb **appointed Muhtasibs (moral police)** to enforce Sharia laws in public, curbing alcohol consumption and regulating gambling dens and prostitution.
- They ensured that laws were not openly flouted.
- The **jizya tax was re-imposed in 1679 on non-Muslims**, except for women, children, the disabled, and the poor.
- Its collection was handled by specially appointed, pious Muslims.



Major Rebellions

- Faced rebellions from various groups:
- Marathas: Shivaji and his son Sambhaji.
- Sikhs: **Guru Tegh Bahadur was executed in 1675**; Guru Gobind Singh rebelled.
- Rajputs, Jats, and Pashtuns.

Political Developments and Expansion of the Empire

- Aurangzeb initially focused on consolidating Mughal authority and recovering lost territories.
- He did not immediately aim for conquest but intervened where disobedience was seen.

- In Assam, after the initial success of **Mir Jumla** in subduing the Ahoms, Aurangzeb's gains were reversed by 1667 when the Ahoms recaptured Guwahati.
- In Bengal, **Shaista Khan's navy defeated the Magh pirates**, leading to Mughal control of Chittagong, which boosted Bengal's economy.
- Aurangzeb's aggressive Deccan policy resulted in the **annexation of Bijapur and Golconda in 1686-87**, but it drained Mughal resources and weakened the empire's finances.

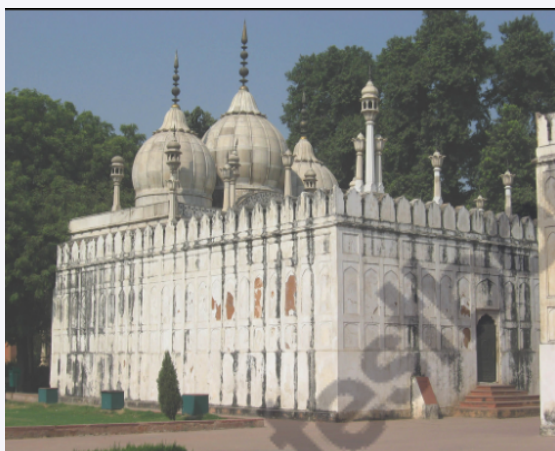
Territorial Expansion under Aurangzeb



- Guerrilla warfare tactics by Marathas drained imperial resources.
- Failed to suppress the long-standing Maratha resistance.

Cultural and Architectural Contributions

- Unlike his predecessors, Aurangzeb did not invest much in grand architecture but focused on the repair and maintenance of existing monuments.
- Aurangzeb was a **skilled calligrapher**, promoting Islamic calligraphy, particularly in the Naskh script. He also encouraged the use of Persian in administration.
- He built notable structures such as the **Moti Masjid in Delhi and the Badshahi Mosque in Lahore.**
- The **Bibi ka Maqbara, built by his son in Aurangabad**, is among the few exceptions to his minimal architectural patronage.



Moti Masjid (Delhi)



Bibi ka Maqbara (Aurangabad)

Decline and Death

End of Reign:

- By the end of his reign, the Mughal Empire was facing internal weaknesses, strained finances, and increasing rebellions.
- His successors were unable to maintain the empire's vast territories.

Death:

- Died in Ahmednagar during a campaign in 1707 at the age of 88.

- Succeeded by his son Azam Shah, but soon after, his half-brother Shah Alam became emperor (Bahadur Shah I).

Legacy:

- Aurangzeb's reign marked the peak of the Mughal Empire but also the beginning of its decline.
- His religious policies, military expansions, and administrative decisions strained the empire's resources, leading to its fragmentation after his death.